decisive action in the midst of difficulties. Not just that, he is also closely associated with nation-building and systemic reform. For all these reasons, he emerges as a natural inspiration for New India.

Seventy-five years ago, both the world and India were experiencing a different kind of turbulence, one no less in its seriousness. The Second World War had just ended, comprehensively overturning the global order. New centres of dominance emerged with very different interests and outlook. Forces set into motion, many predating the conflict, eventually ended colonial rule in many parts of the globe. At home, of course, the endurance and determination of our independence struggle finally prevailed. But it did so at the cost of the partition of our country, with all its accompanying consequences.

This was the context when Patel ascended the leadership stage and took on the immediate challenges of nation-building. He was already recognized as among our pre-eminent leaders, admired for his political vision as much as for his organizational skills. On the assumption of power, he took on the most daunting responsibilities of governance, characteristically setting his personal interests aside. It is generally agreed that he was the preferred leader of his own organization, but he eventually yielded to the choice of Mahatma Gandhi in that regard. And it is this period of his national leadership that holds the most relevant lessons for us today.

In the popular mind, Patel is seen as responsible for the accession of Jammu & Kashmir, Hyderabad and Junagadh. In reality, his contribution was even greater. In fact, these examples, challenging as they were, took place on a firm foundation that he had laid through a set of high-stakes and fast-paced negotiations with many other Princely States. To those unfamiliar, it is necessary to underline that even some southern Princely States were reluctant initially to sign the Instrument of Accession. Certain British officials from the Political Department deliberately encouraged many rulers to hold out, suggesting that a ‘third force’ created through aggregation could be viable. As a result, each state had to be individually and painstakingly engaged. In that process, some actually went to the very brink. Those geographically more contiguous to West Pakistan were tempted by Jinnah’s ostensibly generous offers. It finally took the enormous pressure exerted by Patel to ensure their accession. There were smaller principalities that were being difficult too, often instigated from behind by larger ones. It was only in early August 1947 that the tide turned decisively.